

Editorial

Levelling The Field

ALL THROUGH MY first visit to Europe way back in 1997 I had a tough time correcting the snake charmer and poverty-ridden perception of India. Whenever I said I was from India, the discussion would invariably veer to cows and dogs on streets, slums, or mystic gurus. Europeans just didn't seem to understand that India had moved on: to them, the fact that cable television had taken off in India and that we had 40 TV channels was a revelation.

It's not hard to guess that India's success at IT has changed that perception. Today when I go abroad, I don't need to mention India's increasing GDP growth rate: they now know it, and regard us as having arrived. What seems surprising—but shouldn't—is that they also want to be associated with us, forging alliances with our companies, and opening up their markets for us.

Recently, at the NASSCOM India Leadership Forum 2006, a large Chinese delegation walked in on the first day, listening quietly to Indian success stories, and possibly also picking up a tip or two on organising such events to attract business.

At the same event, the UK Trade & Investment body hosted a special evening in an attempt to entice Indian IT companies to invest in the UK. This made me ponder. I mean, wasn't India up until now scouting around for big MNCs willing to invest in our country and set up their manufacturing units in our hinterlands?

The tables seem to have turned. Was it possibly the beginning of reverse colonisation? A time when India is wooed for its *rupees*?

I attended the Intel Developer Forum in Bangalore a few months ago, where not just the Intel team, but also companies from Europe, Asia-Pacific and the North America participated, putting on display their hardware, software and IT services. I was greeted at every exhibit, and the companies took a keen interest in tending to my queries. The fact that it's usually been us Indians who have been at the other side of the table—ready to serve foreigners—almost made me wonder what was wrong!

With our promising GDP figures, it seems we now have the opportunity to not just play the international trade game, but also reinvent the rules. The fact that the UK and many other countries are vying for a share of India's FDI in their



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territory brings to mind the title of Pulitzer Prize winner Thomas Friedman's book, *The World Is Flat*. If you don't believe me about us being able to reinvent the rules, here's Friedman on Russia, China and India: “Three billion people who were out of the game walked onto the playing field.”

Yes, we've walked onto the playing field. And it's being levelled. So now, I don't need to wonder what's “wrong” when I see a Westerner coming up to me and asking me, “How may I help you?”

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